Bodo Cultural Heritage: Jou & Amaw

Category: FOOD | Region: Assam | Status: needs_check

Bibliographic Citation & Provenance:

The Kacháris (Sidney Endle, 1911); Bodoland Tourism culture page

Narrative & Cultural Documentation:

Jou (historically documented as Zu or Zaw) is the traditional fermented rice beverage of the Bodos, essential to community hospitality, festive seasons like Bwisagu, and agricultural celebrations. It is prepared using an indigenous herbal starter cake known as Amaw (or Emao). The cake is crafted by pounding husked rice together with wild medicinal leaves and jungle plants (including jackfruit leaves and bhetai), molded into discs, sun-dried, and stored over the domestic hearth. When mixed with boiled rice in earthenware vessels (Kalas or Hathorkhi), it undergoes natural fermentation. Different varieties include Jou Bidwi (concentrated sweet brew used in rituals) and Jou Gwrlwi (light beverage served to guests).